



THE LORD OF THE RINGS THE BATTLE FOR MIDDLE-EARTH II

It's here, Precioussssss...

Long days have passed since the first rumours spread from the West—*The Battle for Middle Earth* would begin again, this time with more fire than ever before. We clutched our swords in anticipation and excitement; finally, the War is upon us.

We live in boring times—the RTS (Real-Time Strategy) genre has grown weary now. Nothing revolutionary has happened in the area for many eons, with game developers relying more on theme and setting than concept. The need to innovate seems horrifyingly low when you consider that nearly all the gripes we ever had about strategy games have been addressed by now, and any RTS built with a little common sense is perfectly enjoyable.

Middle Earth

As with all the recent *LOTR*-based games, *Battle For Middle Earth 2 (BFME2)* is

truer to the movies rather than the book, and so, takes the same liberties with the plot that the movies did. Still, there's nothing here that counts as blasphemy by any standard, so fans will be content with shutting up and just enjoying it. Middle Earth has been set up beautifully—the atmosphere is exactly what you would expect from a game based on the movie. You're going to need a graphics card infused with some elven magic to truly take in these wondrous lands—my NVIDIA 6600 started crying for mercy when I turned up the settings to High at 1024 x 768 and will probably go on strike if I try the Ultra High settings at 1280 x 1024. Even at Medium, though, it's one of the best-looking games we've seen.

The game follows the many battles that took place in the book (and its appendices), including the two legendary confrontations at Helm's Deep and Minas Tirith—which will now go down in history among the greatest RTS missions of all

